

The Great Sphinx

One of the world's biggest sculptures, which stands as a tomb guardian in Giza's sands

The Great Sphinx—a massive limestone statue of the mythical creature with the body of a lion and the head of a king—stands in front of the pyramid of the Pharaoh Khafre at Giza and adjacent to his valley temple. Built during Pharaoh Khafre's reign (2520–2465 BCE), approximately 240 ft (73 m) long and 66 ft (20 m) high, it is dynastic Egypt's first ever monumental statue.

The statue may originally have included the distinctive blue-and-yellow striped Nemes headdress often worn by Egyptian pharaohs, with its two flaps that fall over the shoulders. The sphinx's facial features are generally thought to resemble those of Khafre, although several commentators have suggested that the statue depicts Khufu, Khafre's father.

A symbol of omnipotence

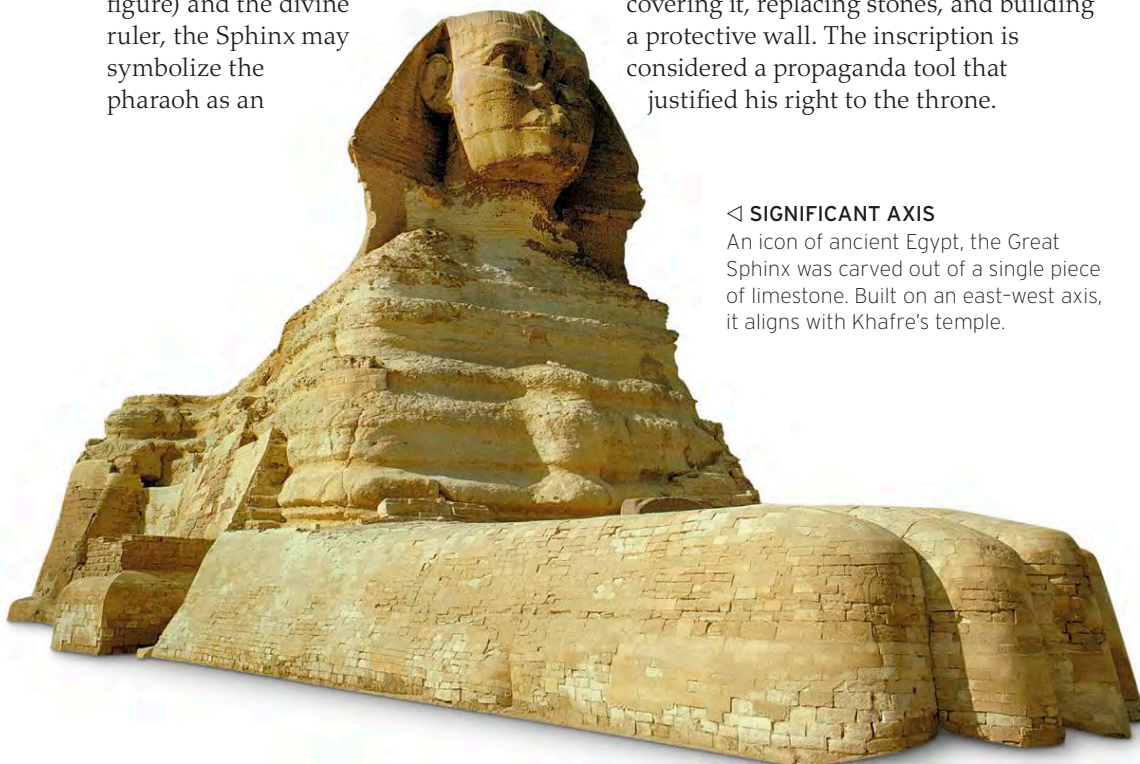
A fusion of the lion (king of the beasts, a symbol of royalty, and a guardian figure) and the divine ruler, the Sphinx may symbolize the pharaoh as an

omniscient and omnipotent ruler. The lion is also associated with the Sun: the sphinx at Giza faces the rising Sun and, when viewed from the east-southeast, its head appears flanked by the two pyramids behind it. Some scholars argue that this configuration resembles the hieroglyph for “horizon” (a Sun disk between two mountains) and is associated with the Sun god Hor-em-akhet (“Horus in the Horizon”), the name that, centuries later, the Egyptians of the New Kingdom (c.1539–1075 BCE) gave the Sphinx.

By the New Kingdom, the Great Sphinx was in disrepair. A red granite stela, known as the Dream Stela, erected by Thutmose IV (r. c.1400–1390 BCE), records a dream he had when he was a prince. In it, the sphinx appears to Thutmose, promising him the throne if he makes repairs to the statue. Thutmose did indeed make various repairs to the sphinx before he became king, including removing sand that was covering it, replacing stones, and building a protective wall. The inscription is considered a propaganda tool that justified his right to the throne.

◁ SIGNIFICANT AXIS

An icon of ancient Egypt, the Great Sphinx was carved out of a single piece of limestone. Built on an east-west axis, it aligns with Khafre's temple.



△ ANCIENT AND MODERN

In this aerial view, taken from the south of modern-day Cairo, Giza's massive, majestic pyramids tower over the densely packed high-rise buildings of the sprawling metropolis, creating a juxtaposition of Egypt's ancient and modern worlds.

A HIDDEN CHAMBER

In 2017, a vast cavity 98 ft (30 m) or more in length, thought to be a secret chamber, was detected above the Grand Gallery in Khufu's Great Pyramid. The breakthrough was made by means of muon analysis—a technique that uses sensors to detect subatomic particles called muons in order to generate three-dimensional images of volumes.

